



A fitting memorial

Heritage group lobbies for plaque to remember train crash of 1942

By Lois Tuffin
Assistant editor
Members of Almonte's heritage group don't want anyone to forget the train crash of 1942.

Dec. 27 of that year 36 people died and 155 were injured when a troop train drove into the back of a full passenger train. Surprisingly, no one from Almonte was killed or injured.

"I don't like to dwell on the accident," said survivor Mervin Tosh. "However it was one of the worst railway accidents in Canada and maybe it should have a plaque."

Tosh is working with survivor John Dunn and heritage supporter Cliff Bennett to lobby the Historic Sites and Monuments Board of Canada to recognize the significance of this event.

The men said they will suggest building a vandal-proof stone pyramid or placing a large boulder on the triangle of land across from the Royal Bank. A brass plaque bolted on the stone would explain what happened in English and French.

The board does not consider "tragedies unless they had a significant impact on the way we do things in Canada," Bennett said.

Within a year, the Almonte wreck inspired changes in Canada's rail signal system which warns other trains if those ahead of them are running behind schedule.

Bennett said he was spurred to act when someone noted the event was mentioned in a walking tour of the town, yet nothing physical showed the actual site.

By having a physical reminder, the event will remain "part of the communal memory," said Sietze Praamsma, chairman of the Local Architectural Conservation Advisory Committee.

He added a plaque may draw tourists or other survivors of the crash.

The board gets about 60 requests a year for commemorative plaques, said Larry Friend, its executive secretary.

Of those, 30 are usually approved, he added.

The board will probably look at the Almonte request at its fall session, Friend said, the board's second of the year.

Other federal historic plaques are bolted on Millfall Condominiums (a former woolen mill) and the Old Post Office.



Welcome to 1994

Mary-Ann Duval of Carleton Place unveils the first baby born in 1994 at the Almonte General Hospital. Duval's first child, Kayla Durant, weighed in at seven pounds, one ounce when she arrived at 2:30 p.m. Jan. 1. Photo by Lois Tuffin.

Youth knocked out during January 1st roadside robbery

A good Samaritan had a rude introduction to the new year when he was robbed early Jan. 1.

At 1:30 a.m. a 17-year-old high school student stopped along County Road 16 to help a pair of men who had the hood of their vehicle up.

As he approached the car, a man bent over in the back seat turned around and punched the student, knocking him to the ground. Another punch rendered him unconscious.

When the student came around, the men, the car and some of the contents

of his wallet were gone. He lost a small amount of cash and his student card. Since it was dark and the assault happened so fast, the youth did not get a good look at his assailants.

The car was a white mid-sized Pontiac with red primer on the left rear quarter-panel, according to police. It was facing west when the young man stopped.

They are inviting anyone with information to call Const. John Boyd at 1-800-267-8919 or Crime Stoppers at 1-800-267-7878.

New bingo hall worries Almonte Civitan Club

Service group dismayed over potential loss of 75 per cent of its annual revenue

By Ryland Coyne
Gazette editor

A proposed big-money bingo hall in neighboring Carleton Place is proving to be a big headache for Almonte's Civitan members.

The club has operated its own weekly bingo at the local community centre for years and, together with the sale of Nevada tickets, depends on them for almost 75 per cent of its annual revenue.

Now the fear is that could all come to an end, says the club's president.

"It's a concern for us and a lot of other organizations," Bruce Toshack said Monday.

The new hall, to be run at the former Produce King grocery store location on Townline Rd. in Carleton Place, will be operated by Lucky 7 Entertainment Ltd. That group received a Class C operating license from the town Nov. 23, 1993 to allow it to run three bingos per week.

The next step is to apply to the Ministry of Consumer and Corporate Affairs for a Class A license to allow for a larger number of bingos at that location.

"We fully expect a Class A license will be issued," lawyer John Hamilton, representing Lucky 7, told Carleton Place council at a meeting late last year. "We feel if we have a Class C license, it will speed up the process...we need municipal support for a Class C license."

The plan is to run three bingos per day, seven days a week, Toshack said he was

told by a Lucky 7 representative.

The Almonte Civitans have been offered a chance to run their bingo there, but he said they're not convinced it would work out. While the potential is there to make money, the group would like to keep its event in Almonte.

On the other hand, there is the concern its players may choose to attend bingo in the Carleton Place hall which would result in a drop in attendance locally. The weekly bingo here averages between 70 and 100 players, Toshack said.

Either way, the new hall has created an air of uncertainty for the local organization. These are already difficult times for fundraising, the new hall simply complicates things further.

"We're very concerned about it," he said. "We're not really sure what to do."

All money raised by the local organization is "turned around back into the community," Toshack said. Any loss in revenue would hamper their community efforts.

Carleton Place council is to be consulted again once Lucky 7 receives its upgraded license. Notice of the license will be published in the local paper and a public meeting may be called at that time if deemed necessary.

"We don't really want to see it, but if it goes, we'll look at it at that time," Toshack said.

With files from the Carleton Place Canadian.

We're looking for a few top coaches

The Almonte area is blessed with many dedicated volunteer coaches. Their hard work ensures youngsters in this area have a sport to play and a means by which to learn more about it.

With this in mind, *The Almonte Gazette* is proud to be a partner with the Coaching Association of Canada and 3M in the Community Coach Recognition Program, honoring community coaches with elegant, gold-tone lapel pins.

Starting Jan. 12, nomination forms will appear in the sports section of the paper.

If you know a coach who is deserving of this award, simply complete the nomination form and mail or fax it to us by Friday, Feb. 11.

Anyone — player, parent, fellow coach — can submit a nomination form. If you've been helped by someone special, here's a chance to give them something back to show how much their work is appreciated.

A local selection committee has been formed to select the winning coaches for

the award. The award winners will then be featured in *The Gazette* in late February.

The 3M/Almonte Gazette Community Coach Recognition Program is a terrific way to show these dedicated coaches just how valuable they truly are to us. Look for the nomination forms in next week's paper.

The Gazette's mailing address is P.O. Box 130, KOA 1A0. Our fax number is 256-5168.



Going downhill

Tony Dugdale, Carl Dugdale, Melissa Hawes, Delyn Debbie O'Meara brace themselves for a ride down Gem-Lewis, Ronnie Dugdale, Dar Tysick, Joy Roberts and mill Park's toboggan hill Dec. 30. Photo by Lois Tuffin

Church raises \$2,000 for international causes

By Lois Tuffin
Assistant editor

The congregation of the Almonte Presbyterian Church is starting the new year with fresh enthusiasm for its pet projects.

Over the past year, it has raised close to \$2,000 for a farming community in Malawi (a country north of Mozambique, Africa) and health care advocates in Cambodia.

The money came from private donations, estates and a large yard sale.

"It creates a sense of purpose that we're accomplishing something of the mission

of the church," Rev. Grant Wilson said.

His own sons — ages three and six — still talk about donating their toys to the yard sale last June "so kids on the other side of the world can have something," he added.

The Almonte money went into a pool that has helped pay to finish a hospital in the town of Battambang, Cambodia and buy a four-wheel-drive vehicle for a medical team, Wilson said.

From now on, the money will go to public health education.

The Malawi farm is "turning out to be a

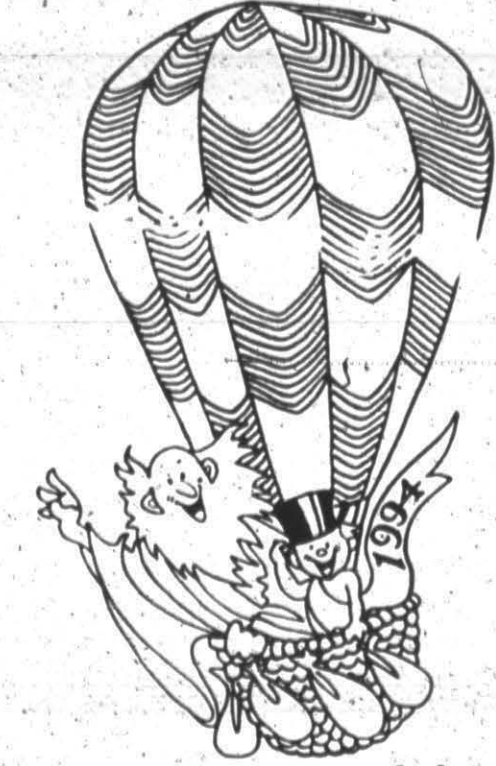
roaring success," said Bill Barrie, an elder at the church.

Almonte's contributions there have helped finance roads and bridges that cross streams on the farm, he said.

A schoolhouse is the next project. Barrie's brother David leaves Friday for Malawi where he trains teachers who, in turn, instruct their peers.

"It's nice when you're giving money to a mission to get some feedback that what you're doing is useful," Barrie said on the reports from his brother.

In focus



Out with the old...

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Former LCBE chairman Audrey McRae died Jan. 2

By Theresa Fritz
Special to the Gazette

Beckwith Township is mourning the loss of its long-time representative on the Lanark County Board of Education (LCBE).

Audrey McRae died suddenly in the Carleton Place hospital Jan. 2. She was 63.

Born Audrey E. Doucett, she married D. Murray McRae. Together they raised Lynda (Jim) Foster, Don (Joyce), Cathy (Jim) Wood, Anne Leroux, Heather (Lyle) Messenger, Jim (Gillian) and Howard (Caroleann).

Mrs. McRae first became an LCBE trustee in 1981. Originally representing Beckwith and Montague Township, redistribution of seats in 1988 meant she stood only for the people of Beckwith.

She was school board chairman from January, 1989 to December, 1990.

An active member of the Zion Memorial United Church in Carleton Place, Mrs. McRae was the trustee of the United Cemeteries of St. Fittians, Maplewood and Pine Grove along with her husband Murray.

Beckwith Township Reeve Stanley Brunton said Tuesday Mrs. McRae provided the township with good representation at the school board.

"She filled the position in a credible way," he said. "She had the capacity to keep everything within her scope."

"She had a good business sense."

Reeve Stanley Brunton

As for her personality, Brunton added this was as distinctive as the woman herself.

"She had a good business sense and was very approachable."

Mrs. McRae is survived by 18 grandchildren and her sister Muriel Doucett.

She was predeceased by brothers Allan and Kenneth Doucett.

Mrs. McRae is resting at the Barker Funeral Home Wednesday from 2 to 4 and 7 to 9 p.m.

She will also be resting at the Zion Memorial United Church in Carleton Place Thursday from noon until the funeral service at 2 p.m.

Interment will take place in the spring at the United Cemeteries. Donations to the University of Ottawa Heart Institute or the United Cemeteries, Carleton Place would be appreciated by the family.